MIRAI MELODY
RECORDS · MILANO

TENTH ANNIVERSARY EDITION
MILAN · DECEMBER 1989



1980 · 1989 · THE BOOK OF THE LABEL

TEN YEARS OF FUTURE

The story, the people and the records of Mirai Melody Records

FREE COPY NOT FOR SALE

GREETINGS FROM RICCARDO AND KEIKO

DEAR FRIENDS



Riccardo, 1985



Keiko, 1985

Ten years ago, in the back room of a shop on Corso Buenos Aires, we pressed our first 45. It had a dark red label, cream lettering and a hand-drawn logo. We had no plan, just one simple rule: if the girl at the counter is humming the chorus the next day, the song is good. It still works.

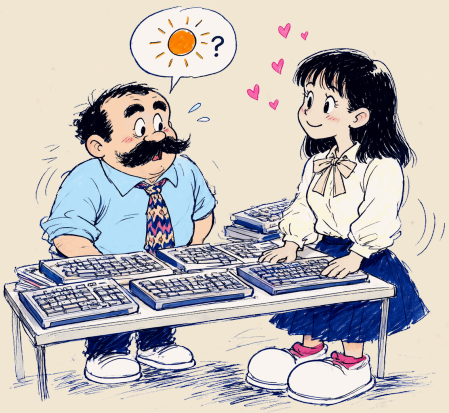
Since 1980 our records have travelled further than we have. In these pages you will find the people, the places and the songs that brought us here. Thank you to all who danced, and still dance, with us.

Riccardo and Keiko

Milan, December 1989

IN THIS BOOK

The story	3
Mirai's Milan and the group	5
The house team	7
The numbers	8
The series	9
The artists	10



FROM THE SHOP TO THE LABEL

1 THE STORY

1971

COLOMBO HI-FI

Riccardo Colombo opens the first shop in Milan to import Japanese synthesizers directly, on Corso Buenos Aires.

1972

THE WORD "FUTURE"

Keiko Morimoto arrives from Osaka as an interpreter. Riccardo asks her how to say "future" in Japanese: *mirai*.

1979

STUDIO MIRAI

The studio is born in the back room: jingles, theme tunes, sessions for others. Mirai Productions is born too.

1980

MMR-001

The label and the publishing house are founded. The first 45 is pressed in the shop.

1981

THE STORIES

R. P., our lyricist, arrives: from now on every record tells of a world.

1982

THE ODYSSEY

The Silver Pulse concept album and, for the World Cup, *Madrid '82*.



1971. *"Novità dal Giappone", new from Japan, said the sign in the window.*



1982. *An Eastern scale during a break, a dance-hall melody: Eastern Pearl are born.*

1983

RADIO FUTURA

102 FM and a Saturday chart that gets all of northern Italy dancing.

1984

THE BOOM

Jade Express, *Totentanz* and the Tokyo office.

1985

THE GOLDEN YEAR

TeleMirai is born, the "M" mark arrives. *Miranda* is the summer.

1986

THE BLACK LINE

Cut the Tie jams the switchboards. The Neonova film remains a dream.

1987

FASTER

Hi-NRG and eurobeat: Automatic Heart, Odissey, Silver Fire.



Proteste dopo la prima serata di domenica: centralino intasato per ore

Videoclip choc: TeleMirai lo sposta dopo mezzanotte

Da stasera il filmato andrà in onda soltanto alle 0.30

Migliaia di telefonate - Divisi i genitori e i ragazzi - Il disco intanto vola in classifica - La rete: «Nessuna censura, solo un orario diverso»

Il centralino di TeleMirai domenica sera, dopo la messa in onda.

MILANO — In serata il centralino ha continuato a ricevere telefonate, molte di protesta e alcune di sostegno. Gli esperti interpellati invitano alla prudenza e ricordano che il pubblico ha strumenti per scegliere. Non sono mancate le polemiche, anche se i responsabili hanno preferito non rilasciare dichiarazioni. La vicenda riprende il tema, più volte sollevato, dei limiti da porre ai programmi in prima serata. In serata il centralino ha continuato a ricevere telefonate, molte di protesta e alcune di sostegno. Il caso ha suscitato un vivace dibattito tra i lettori e negli ambienti della televisione privata. In serata il centralino ha continuato a ricevere telefonate, molte di protesta e alcune di sostegno. Il dibattito si è spostato anche in Parlamento, dove è stata presentata un'interrogazione. Il provvedimento entrerà in vigore dal primo gennaio, salvo modifiche dell'ultima ora. Nelle discoteche della riviera, intanto, il disco continua a girare e le vendite non accennano a calare. Della questione si occuperà nei prossimi giorni la commissione competente, convocata in via straordinaria. Il caso ha suscitato un vivace dibattito tra i lettori e negli ambienti della televisione privata. Per gli inserzionisti la serata è stata comunque un successo, con ascolti superiori alle attese. Secondo quanto si apprende, la decisione sarebbe stata presa nel corso di una riunione durata fino a tarda sera. Nessuno da chiarire alcuni aspetti, sui quali le parti hanno promesso una risposta entro la settimana. Il caso ha suscitato un vivace dibattito tra i lettori e negli ambienti della televisione privata. Secondo quanto si apprende, la decisione sarebbe stata presa nel corso di una riunione durata fino a tarda sera. La notizia ha fatto rapidamente il giro della città, rimbalzando dai bar alle redazioni. Nelle discoteche della riviera, intanto, il disco continua a girare e le vendite non accennano a calare. Gli esperti interpellati invitano alla prudenza e ricordano che il pubblico ha strumenti per scegliere. La vicenda riprende il tema, più volte sollevato, dei limiti da porre ai programmi in prima serata. In serata il centralino ha continuato a ricevere telefonate, molte di protesta e alcune di sostegno. La nebbia ha rallentato il traffico fin dalle prime ore del mattino, soprattutto in periferia. Nelle discoteche della riviera, intanto, il disco continua a girare e le vendite non accennano a calare. La nebbia ha rallentato il traffico fin dalle prime ore del mattino, soprattutto in periferia. Il fenomeno, osservano gli addetti ai lavori, non è nuovo e riguarda ormai tutte le reti del Nord. Della questione si occuperà nei prossimi giorni la commissione competente.

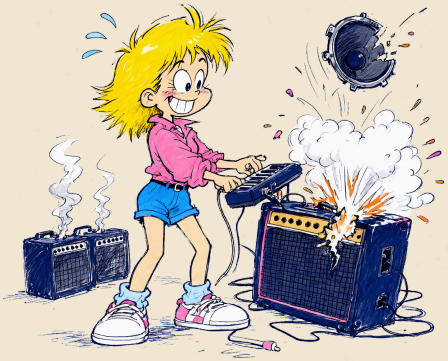
Altri servizi a pagina 17

Anna Valsecchi

10 November 1986. *The morning after prime time: "Shock video: TeleMirai moves it past midnight". Since then Cut the Tie airs only at 12.30 a.m.*

DID YOU KNOW?

The "chainsaw tremolo" of *Cut the Tie* was born like this: a synthesizer through a guitar amp at full volume. Two speakers blown, the third one held.



THE MAP

2 MIRAI'S MILAN

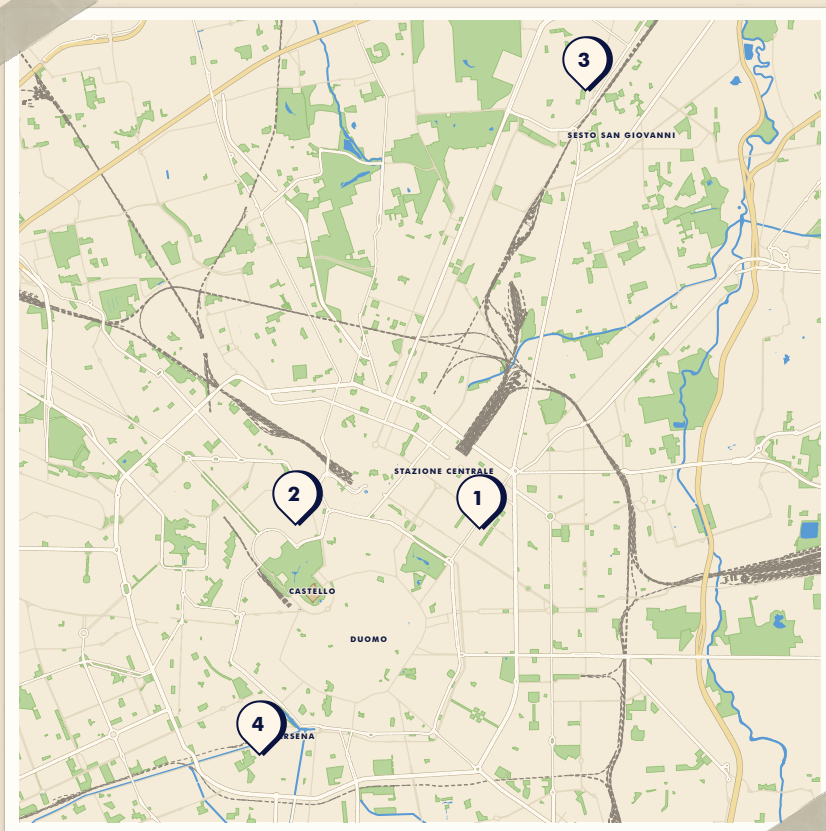


Plate 1. *Milan, from the Navigli to Sesto San Giovanni. Cartography © OpenStreetMap contributors.*

1 **COLOMBO HI-FI**
Corso Buenos Aires. The shop where it all began.

2 **STUDIO MIRAI**
Via Paolo Sarpi. Where Eastern Pearl were born.

3 **TELEMIRAI**
Sesto San Giovanni, the old Breda works: TV studios and mast, 7 km further north.

4 **ARTI GRAFICHE NAVIGLI**
On the Naviglio Grande: sleeves, inner bags and this book.

SIX COMPANIES, ONE "M"

2 THE GROUP

A shop, a studio, a production company, a label. Then a radio station and a TV network. Since 1985 they have all carried the same double-band "M", each in its own colour.

MIRAI PRODUCTIONS
VIDEO · TV · CINEMA · MILANO

SINCE 1979

Videos, programmes, films. Even the unfinished one.

MIRAI MELODY
RECORDS · MILANO

SINCE 1980

The label. MMR catalogue, and MMJ for Japan.

MIRAI PUBLISHING
EDIZIONI MUSICALI · MILANO

SINCE 1980

The music publisher: the copyright of every song.

RADIO FUTURA
FM 102 · RADIO NETWORK

SINCE 1983

FM 102. The network of stations covering northern Italy.

TELEMIRAI

SINCE 1985 · SESTO SAN GIOVANNI

TeleMirai: dozens of linked local stations, the same programme at the same time all over the North.



DID YOU KNOW?

The radio has an Italian name and the TV a Japanese one. *Mirai* means "future": Radio Futura is its translation.

WHO SIGNS THE RECORDS BESIDE THE ARTISTS

3 THE TEAM

PRODUCER

A. FERRANDI SINCE 1981

Aldo Ferrandi (Milan 1946): once a keyboard player in the dance-hall orchestras, he came to Studio Mirai as a session man and since 1981 has produced almost the whole catalogue. He is the one who "hears" the single before anyone else, after Riccardo.

SOUND ENGINEER

G. BRAMBATI SINCE 1980

Giorgio Brambati (Sesto San Giovanni 1952): he has recorded and mixed at Studio Mirai since the very first 45; he followed the studio on its move to Via Paolo Sarpi.

LACQUER CUTTING

P. VISMARA SINCE 1982

Pino Vismara (Monza 1950): he cuts the lacquers of the maxi singles. The "Vismara cut", louder and deeper in the bass, is what German DJs ask for.

PHOTOGRAPHY

S. RONCHI SINCE 1983

Silvia Ronchi (Bergamo 1955): she shoots the sleeves and the promotional photos, working closely with Keiko.

SLEEVE DESIGN

K. MORIMOTO COLOMBO
SINCE 1980

Keiko oversees the label's graphics and sleeves.

PRINTING

ARTI GRAFICHE NAVIGLI, MILAN
SINCE 1980

The print shop on the Naviglio Grande that prints our sleeves, inner bags and labels.



THE DECADE IN FIGURES

4 THE NUMBERS

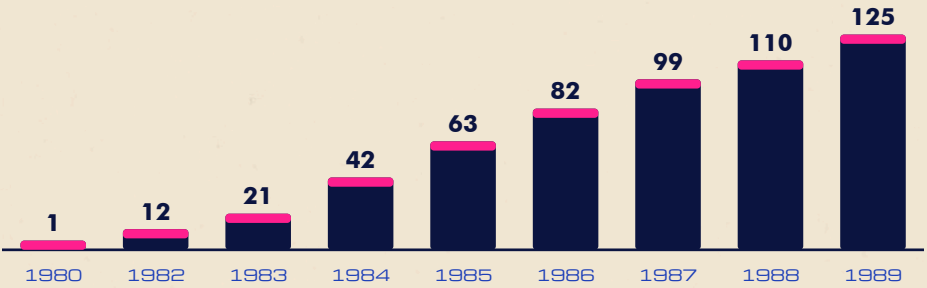
6
COMPANIES IN THE MIRAI GROUP

9
SERIES IN THE CATALOGUE

102
FM · RADIO FUTURA MILAN

THE CATALOGUE GROWS

The last MMR number pressed, year by year. A 7", a maxi and an LP all count the same.



SATURDAYS AT 4 P.M.

If a song climbs the Radio Futura chart on Saturday afternoon, every club plays it that night. On 27 July 1985 the No. 1 is *Miranda*.

WHERE THEY DANCE TO US

Germany · Spain · Poland · the Soviet Union · Japan.





In Poland, pirate Silver Double cassettes circulate with sleeves drawn in felt-tip pen.

EVERY RECORD TELLS OF A WORLD

5 THE SERIES

	SERIES	SOUND AND THEMES	EXAMPLES
	**Mirai Dance** main line	romantic italo disco for the dance floor	Madrid '82, Wild Heart, Burning Love
	**Oriente**	pentatonic melodies, harbours, legends	Shanghai Moon, Jade Express, Travel On, Wanderer
	**Cosmo**	space disco, prog, science fiction	An Odissey in Space, Cosmic Boy, Mission Complete
	**Iron Curtain** since 1984	the Cold War, spies, politics	Serpukhov, Big Business, Virus!, Trans-Siberia
	**Linea nera**	dark italo and Horror Italodisco	Someone on the Line, Totentanz, Shadow of the Game
	**Cinema**	soundtracks, fantasy, westerns	Caballero, Arapaho, Crossing the Line, The Tale the Old Ones Tell
	**Mirai Japan**	city pop, Italy–Japan exchanges	Tokyo Is Magic, Tassoni, Kilimanjaro, Milano Adventure
	**Hi-NRG** 1987–89	fast eurobeat	High Energy Low Control, Lucid Dream, Hit Me Now
	**Mediterranea**	reggae and reworkings	Miranda (Reggae Version)

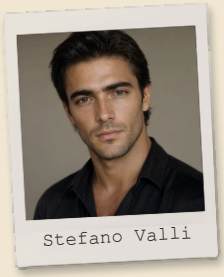
HOW TO READ A CATALOGUE NUMBER

MMR-050 · **MMR** stands for Mirai Melody Records, the number follows the order of release and the format does not matter. Japanese editions have a series of their own, **MMJ**: the Tokyo *Miranda* is MMJ-008.

TWO STORIES FROM THE LABEL

6 THE ARTISTS

EASTERN PEARL · SINCE 1982





STEFANO VALLI
Riccione 1953
Lead vocals.

GIADA TCHOU
Milan 1956
Synthesizers, arrangements, backing vocals.

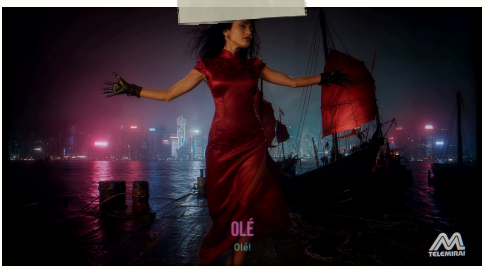
NO.	YEAR	TITLE	
MMR-020	1983	*Shanghai Moon*	
MMR-030	1984	*Jade Express*	
MMR-040	1984	*Travel On, Wanderer*	
MMR-042	1984	*Eastern Pearl*	
MMR-050	1985	*Miranda*	No. 1 Radio Futura



MMR-050 · *Miranda, 1985*

DID YOU KNOW?

Miranda is the hit of summer 1985, from the Riviera to Portugal. In Japan it comes out with an obi strip and takes the duo to a TV studio in Tokyo.



A frame from the Miranda video (1985).

SILVER DOUBLE · SINCE 1983



LENA PICHLER
Bolzano 1960
Synthesizers, programming, vocals on the choruses and the replies.

ELIAS MORO
Trieste 1962
Vocals on the verses and bridges, a cold, theatrical baritone.

NO.	YEAR	TITLE
MMR-031	1984	*Someone on the Line*
MMR-051	1985	*The Man in the Mirror*
MMR-080	1986	*Cut the Tie*
MMR-081	1986	*Bloodbeat*
MMR-082	1986	*Channel 9*
MMR-095	1987	*Room 17*
MMR-096	1987	*The Endless Feast*
MMR-097	1987	*No Return*



MMR-080 · *Cut the Tie, 1986*

DID YOU KNOW?

In Japan *Cut the Tie* comes out with a blood-red strip, in few copies: it lands in the horror section of Tokyo's record shops and becomes a small cult.



The Domenica Sera studio in the Cut the Tie video (1986).



MIRAI MELODY RECORDS

RECORDS · MILAN

Mirai Melody is an imagined label: this book is part of a work of fiction, made with the help of AI by a solo creator in Italy.

℗ 1989 Mirai Melody Records · © Ed. Mirai Publishing
Texts and photographs from the label's archives · Printed by Arti Grafiche Navigli, Milan
LC 1980 · Distributed by Mirai Melody Records, Milan · Printed in Italy